

If we wanted to make money, we wouldn't have been doubles players. We chose doubles because we genuinely liked playing doubles a lot more than singles. Now, things have definitely changed. The youngsters nowadays have that option where they can see themselves having a good career playing doubles.

Going into the Olympic season, have you and Matthias planned anything different?

Chirag: He wants us to win a medal and so do we, but there's still 7-8 months to go. We keep really short-term targets. We would completely start thinking about the Olympics just a month or two before it. That is the ultimate goal, but we have many tournaments leading up to it. We would like to do well in those tournaments and then start thinking about the Olympics.

You have been working with Matthias since before the last Olympics. What do you think is unique about the way you work with him?

Satwik: He has a more strategic mindset (compared to the other coaches we have worked with). He has played with all these players who are there in the circuit right now. He knows their weaknesses and what can be done to exploit them. He isn't someone who played 10-15 years ago and is now a coach. He himself was on the circuit only 3-4 years ago and knows what needs to be done. He doesn't have that physical game but is smart. On the other hand, we are very physically strong. We have the capacity to play those two-hour long matches. When he came here, he added that smartness to our game. We now have a game plan before we enter the court for different situations we might be in, and we try to stick to it. Our practice sessions focus more on the mental aspect than just the physical one. Our sessions are quite short — around 1 hour 10-20 minutes — but they have a lot more intensity.

Unlike in the past, you have managed to stay relatively injury-free this year. Is there

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anything you've been doing?

Satwik: I actually got injured at the Malaysia Open at the start of the year but that was something that I picked up in a match. You can't avoid those. But I took a break after that until the All England. From then on, I started observing my body and when it required me to take rest. We had a talk with our coach that when I start feeling like my body needs rest, then we are not playing any tournament. This year we didn't play so many tournaments. But when we entered the tournament, we were playing 100 per cent. Like, once you're fit, you're playing, otherwise you don't. So that has helped us.

In doubles you work as a team but what happens when one of you is injured. Is it frustrating for the

other partner?

Chirag: You feel bad, but injuries are a part and parcel of the game. If you are putting yourselves through so much training and stress, the body is bound to get injured at some point. Obviously, you need to take care of it.

One needs to be supportive of their injured partner. If you are a singles player your fitness is your sole responsibility — it's your body, and if you get injured, you lose money, matches, or whatever. But in a doubles partnership, you need to think about your partner. It's like a

